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ORIGINAL PAPER

Too Close for Comfort? Investigating the Nature and Functioning of Work and Non-work Role Segmentation Preferences

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Abstract
Purpose We examine the bi-directional nature of role segmentation preferences—*preferences to protect the home domain from work intrusions*, and *to protect the work domain from home intrusions*—and hypothesize that the dimensions independently prompt individuals to manage their boundaries in ways that complement their preferences.
Design and Methodological Approach In a series of three studies, we investigate whether segmentation preferences vary on two dimensions, how they reflect enactive and proactive boundary management, and their association with domain-specific satisfaction and performance.
Findings In Study 1 (field design, $n = 314$), we confirmed that segmentation preferences comprise two distinct dimensions, and individuals experience fewer intrusions into the domain they desired to protect. In Study 2 (experimental design, $n = 1253$), we found that participants who prefer to protect their home domain are less inclined to accept jobs in scenarios where their significant other is employed in the same organization, and participants who prefer to protect their work domain are less inclined to initiate a romantic relationship in scenarios that involve a coworker. In Study 3 (field design, $n = 65$), we found that individuals who prefer to protect their work or home domain report greater satisfaction with the preferred domain, and whereas the preference to protect the work domain is not associated with higher supervisor ratings of job performance, preference to protect the home domain is associated with higher significant-other ratings of non-work performance.
Implications Understanding employees' proclivities to blur boundaries can inform recruitment and selection of employees to anticipate organizational fit, diagnose sources of misfit, structure individualized policies to ameliorate employee strain, and decrease turnover costs.
Originality/Value This synthesis provides a unique investigation of segmentation preference dimensions' differential functioning and reinforces the validity of the role segmentation preferences concept.

Keywords Work-life balance · Role segmentation preferences · Boundary management · Boundary permeability · Job acceptance · Workplace romance

Introduction

A growing body of literature loosely labeled "boundary theory" (Ashforth et al. 2000; Clark 2000; Nippert-Eng 1996) explores ways people manage boundaries between work and personal domains. This research asserts that boundary management strategies—the process in which people "organize potentially realm-specific matters, people, objects, and aspects of self into 'home' and 'work'" (Nippert-Eng 1996, p. 7)—range on a continuum from segmentation to integration (Ashforth et al. 2000; Clark 2000; Edwards and Rothbard 2000; Kreiner 2006; Rothbard et al. 2005). Individuals can prefer to segment work and home by compartmentalizing cognitions, behaviors, and physical objects into mutually exclusive role

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characteristics, or they can prefer to integrate by allowing these role characteristics to intermingle across work and personal domains (Ashforth et al. 2000). In short, people are viewed as differing systematically in their *role segmentation preferences*, or their desire to create and maintain physical, temporal, or cognitive boundaries between work and personal domains (Edwards and Rothbard 2000; Kreiner 2006; Rothbard et al. 2005).

Although research related to this topic has furnished valuable insights, our understanding of the nature of role segmentation preferences remains limited in three key ways. First, extant literature is underdeveloped regarding the degree to which individual preferences may vary in direction and symmetry (Kossek and Laustch 2012). Current theory tends to consider how general preferences range on a continuum from complete segmentation to complete integration of work and home (Ashforth et al. 2000; Kanter 1977; Kirchmeyer 1995; Nippert-Eng 1996; Ollier-Malaterre et al. 2013; Zerubavel 1991), and empirical investigations focus on preferences to keep work segmented from home (Kreiner 2006; Powell and Greenhaus 2007, 2010; Paustian-Underdahl et al. 2013; Rothbard et al. 2005). Yet, these approaches overlook the possibility that individuals vary in their preference to protect the work domain from interference created by family responsibilities relative to their preference to protect the family domain from interference created by work responsibilities (Kossek and Laustch 2012; Powell and Greenhaus 2007).

Second, research rarely decouples *experienced* from *preferred* segmentation or integration (Rothbard et al. 2005). Because it is well established that an individual's boundary management strategy is shaped both by individual differences as well as the structure of one's job (Kossek et al. 2005), researchers have tended to emphasize how characteristics of individuals' work and personal lives enhance or constrain their ability to activate their preferred boundary management strategies (Ashforth et al. 2000; Kreiner 2006; Rothbard et al. 2005). Although this research has helped us understand how people with certain preferred boundary management strategies respond to intrusions from one domain into the other, and how these responses manifest in outcomes such as inter-role conflict and enhancement (Bulger et al. 2007; Hecht and Allen 2009; Matthews and Barnes-Farrell 2010; Olson-Buchanan and Boswell 2006), research has yet to consider how individuals proactively integrate or segment their work and non-work domains to fit their preferences (Clark 2000). Accordingly, our understanding of a significant and vital aspect of segmentation preferences is incomplete.

Finally, researchers have confined examinations of outcomes of role segmentation preferences to emotions and attitudes, and emphasized outcomes specific to the non-work domain. Indeed, evidence suggests that mismatch between individuals' preferences and their experiences can generally be disruptive (Ashforth et al. 2000), increase feelings of work-life conflict (Olson-Buchanan and Boswell 2006), deplete personal resources (Park et al. 2011), and reduce well-being (Edwards and Rothbard 1999). Although some researchers suggest these preferences are also relevant to outcomes in the work domain (e.g., job satisfaction and organizational commitment; Rothbard et al. 2005), researchers have yet to explore how these preferences may facilitate effectiveness with respect to performance (Edwards and Rothbard 1999), which in general, can be defined as the value of the activities an individual contributes to the effectiveness of the focal unit (Borman and Motowidlo 1993). Thus, our understanding of role segmentation preferences could be improved by considering a broader set of their implications, especially those related to performance in both the work and personal domains.

With these limitations in mind, the overarching purpose of this research is to enhance our understanding of the nature and functioning of role segmentation preferences. Grounding our expectations in identity (Pratt 1998; Tajfel and Turner 1986) and person–environment fit theories (Kristof 1996), we develop hypotheses related to the issues discussed above and test them in three studies. First, we examine how individuals' segmentation preferences vary from high to low on two independent dimensions: *preference to protect their home domain* from work intrusions and *preference to protect their work domain* from non-work intrusions (Powell and Greenhaus 2007). Next, we explore how these two preferences for segmentation reflect enactive and proactive approaches to managing boundaries (Clark 2000). Specifically, we develop and test hypotheses regarding how individuals manage fit between their preferences and their domain participation. We examine how individuals' preferences match the extent to which their existing work and non-work domain boundaries allow intrusions, and also how they proactively manage boundaries associated with multiple domains by selecting into work and non-work domains that are consistent with their preferred degree of segmentation. Finally, we examine associations among these preferences and domain-specific satisfaction and performance.

Study 1: Examination of Dimensionality and Enactive Boundary Management

The Bi-directional Nature of Role Segmentation and Integration

Most theoretical conceptualizations of segmentation preferences describe a general preference to keep work and non-work matters from interfering with each other to an equal degree (e.g., Kreiner 2006; Nippert-Eng 1996), such that individuals with strong segmentation preferences desire to keep work matters at work *and* family matters at home (Kirchmeyer 1995; Powell and Greenhaus 2007). Further, scholars who have examined segmentation preferences tend to measure them solely from the direction of preferring to protect the home domain from work intrusions (Kreiner 2006; Powell and Greenhaus 2007). This focus is due to interest in understanding effects of policies such as flexible work arrangements (Chen et al. 2009; Hyland et al. 2005; Rothbard et al. 2005) and recovering from stressful work experiences (Park et al. 2011).

Other scholars have suggested, however, that preferences regarding segmentation of work and home are distinct, and that they function bi-directionally and asymmetrically (Kossek and Laustch 2012; Powell and Greenhaus 2007). This view is supported by theory and research that describes how meaningfulness and identity vary across the roles an individual holds (e.g., Ashforth et al. 2000; Clark 2000; Olson-Buchanan and Boswell 2006), which consequently result in individuals differing in the priority they give to demands within and across domains (Hecht and Allen 2009). These differences in preferences have been supported indirectly in research. For example, Matthews and colleagues investigated individuals' "willingness" to allow intrusions from one domain to another (Matthews and Barnes-Farrell 2010; Matthews et al. 2010) and concluded that work and non-work dimensions function independently. Similarly, Edwards and Rothbard (1999) were concerned with the degree to which people value keeping their work domain insulated from their personal domain, and vice versa, by focusing on "acceptable amounts" of interference from one domain to another.

Consistent with this emerging view, we propose that individuals range from high to low in their preference to protect their home domain from work, and from high to low in their preference to protect their work domain from home (Powell and Greenhaus 2007). An individual who is high (low) on both dimensions prefers to segment (integrate) work and home to an equal degree, exemplifying the typical interpretation of a high (low) role segmentation preference. However, we predict that the dimensions are distinct and relatively independent. An individual can have a high preference to protect their home domain from work interference and, simultaneously, have a low preference to protect their work domain from home interference. This configuration of preferences could be reflected in decisions not to answer work-related phone calls at home, but having no problem answering calls from family while at work. Another individual can have a low preference to protect their home domain and, simultaneously, have a high preference to protect their work domain. This configuration of preferences could manifest in decisions not to answer calls from family while at work, but at the same time, having no problem answering work-related phone calls at home. With this reasoning in mind, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 1 Role segmentation preferences have two dimensions such that the preference to protect the home domain is distinct from the preference to protect the work domain.

Enactive Boundary Management

Two distinct dimensions of role segmentation preferences provide for the potential for a more complete understanding of how individuals make boundary management decisions. *Boundaries* refer to "the physical, temporal, emotional, cognitive, and/or relational limits that define entities as separate from one another" (Ashforth et al. 2000, p. 474). Boundaries between domains are characterized by how *permeable* they are—similar to concepts such as boundary strength (Clark 2000; Hecht and Allen 2009), flexibility (Ashforth et al. 2000; Bulger et al. 2007; Hall and Richter 1988), and role-referencing (Olson-Buchanan and Boswell 2006)—which refers to the degree to which elements (e.g., thoughts, actions, emotions) from other domains may enter. Permeable boundaries are considered weak and allow domain "blending," whereby an individual can be physically located in one domain, yet psychologically or behaviorally engaged in another (Hecht and Allen 2009). Importantly, the permeability of boundaries between domains can have significant implications for individuals, and there are reasons to believe that individuals take an active role in their management.

A central tenet of boundary theory is that individuals create and maintain "mental fences" (Zerubavel 1991, p. 2) around domains to organize and simplify their environment (Ashforth et al. 2000; Clark 2000; Nippert-Eng 1996; Zerubavel 1991). By virtue of this process, boundary permeability, and by extension segmentation or integration, results, in part, from the efforts of individuals to actively manage the boundary between work and non-work to align with their segmentation preferences (Eckenrode and Gore 1990; Kreiner 2006; Powell and Greenhaus 2010). This reasoning is consistent with Matthews and Barnes-Farrell's (2010) findings that individuals' willingness to integrate their work into their personal lives was positively correlated with the degree to which their non-work domain boundary was permeable, and similarly, their willingness to integrate personal aspects into the work domain was positively correlated with work boundary permeability. Thus, although characteristics of the work context and individual's personal lives may restrict full activation of their preferences by coercing permeable or impermeable boundaries (Kreiner 2006; Rothbard et al. 2005)—for example, the use of communication technologies that weaken domain boundaries and increase the vulnerability of work and non-work domains to "externally imposed penetrations" (Hall and Richter 1988)—we nevertheless expect that people express their preference to protect their work domain by maintaining an impermeable work domain border, and express their preference to protect their home domain by maintaining an impermeable home domain border (Powell and Greenhaus 2007).

Hypothesis 2 Segmentation preferences are associated with less permeability of non-work and work domain boundaries. Specifically, (a) preference to protect the non-work domain will be negatively associated with home boundary permeability and (b) preference to protect the work domain will be negatively associated with work boundary permeability.

Method

Participants and Procedure

Participants were employees from a large U.S. company in the insurance industry. To solicit participation, the HR manager sent an email to employees with information regarding the study. The email emphasized that participation was voluntary, and that responses to the survey would be kept confidential by the researchers. The email instructed interested employees to click on a link directing them to an electronic survey that assessed demographics and items relevant to the study. Three hundred and fourteen employees completed the survey. Women comprised 83.9 % of the sample, and 56.5 % of respondents were married. On average, respondents worked 38.9 hours per week, and performed a variety of jobs, including customer service, claims representative, commercial underwriter, quality assurance, and claims adjuster. From information provided by our company contact, the characteristics of our sample are consistent with that of the organization. In exchange for participation, employees were given $5.

Measures

Role Segmentation Preferences

We used Kreiner's (2006) four-item scale to assess *preferences to protect the home domain*. This measure has demonstrated sound psychometric properties in prior research (Chen et al. 2009; Kreiner 2006; Park et al. 2011; Powell and Greenhaus 2010). Items include "I don't like to think about work issues while I am at home," and "I like being able to leave work issues behind when I go home." We wrote parallel items that tap *preferences to protect the work domain*: "I don't like to think about non-work issues while I am at work," "I like being able to leave non-work issues behind when I go to work", "I prefer to keep non-work life at home", and "I don't like non-work issues creeping into my work life." Participants indicated agreement with the items using a five-point scale (1 = strongly disagree to 5 = strongly agree). The two scales exhibit adequate reliability ($\alpha = 0.91$ and 0.86, respectively).

Boundary Permeability

We measured the degree to which employees perceive their work and non-work boundaries as permeable using items adapted from measures of boundary strength, boundary permeability, and role-referencing (Hecht and Allen 2009; Olson-Buchanan and Boswell 2006) using a five-point scale (1 = strongly disagree to 5 = strongly agree). *Non-work boundary permeability* included four items: "I tend to perform work-related tasks while at home", "I often think about work tasks while at home", "Activities and experiences in the work context are rarely incorporated into my non-work life "(reverse-coded), and "I do not perceive any intrusions from my work life into my non-work life" (reverse-coded). *Work boundary permeability* included five items: "I have a tendency to think about non-work tasks while at work", "I often perform non-work related tasks (for example, paying bills) while at work", "My non-work life often intrudes into my work life", "There is a significant degree of overlap between my non-work and work lives", and "Activities and experiences in my non-work life rarely affect my work life" (reverse-coded). Coefficient alphas for these scales are 0.73. and 0.63, respectively.

Controls

We controlled for gender, marital status, number of children under the age of 18, and hours worked per week because they may relate to the core variables in our study.

Analyses and Results

Using Mplus 6.0 (Muthén and Muthén 1998–2010), we conducted a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) by specifying the two-factor model (preference to protect home and preference to protect work) and comparing it to a one-factor model with all of the indicators loading onto a general role segmentation preference factor. Hypothesis 1 states that the preference to protect the home domain is distinct from the preference to protect the work domain. The Chi square and fit statistics indicate that a two-factor model

[χ^2 (19, $n = 312$) = 61.34; CFI = 0.97; SRMR = 0.03; RMSEA = 0.08] fits the data significantly better than does a one-factor model [χ^2 (20, $n = 312$) = 594.263; CFI = 0.65; SRMR = 0.18; RMSEA = 0.30]. Factor loadings specified in the two-factor measurement model are statistically significant (0.72–0.91; t values, 10.76–19.47). Further, results indicate that preference to protect the home domain and preference to protect the work domain are only moderately correlated ($r = 0.27$), providing further support of two distinct dimensions. Thus, our results provide strong support for Hypothesis 1.

Table 1 reports the means, standard deviations, and correlations. Consistent with our expectations, preference to protect the home domain is negatively and significantly correlated with home permeability ($r = -0.18$, $p < 0.01$), and preference to protect the work domain is negatively and significantly correlated with work permeability ($r = -0.18$, $p < 0.01$), such that individuals tend to experience fewer external intrusions into the domain they wish to protect. We conducted a series of hierarchical regressions to test our hypotheses, which are reported in Table 2. Results in the third step of each regression provide support for Hypotheses 2a and 2b, respectively. Specifically, preference to protect that home domain negatively and significantly predicts home boundary permeability ($\beta = -0.18$, $p < 0.01$), suggesting that individuals with a preference to prevent work from intruding into their non-work lives do, in fact, experience fewer work intrusions. Further, preference to protect the work domain negatively and significantly predicts work boundary permeability ($\beta = -0.17$, $p < 0.01$), suggesting individuals with a preference to prevent non-work issues from intruding into their work lives do, in fact, experience fewer non-work intrusions. While not hypothesized, there is evidence that the two segmentation preference dimensions

Table 1 Means, standard deviations, and intercorrelations between Study 1 variables

	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Gender[a]	0.81	0.39	–							
2. Marital status[b]	0.62	0.49	−0.11	–						
3. Hours worked per week	39.23	9.25	−0.16**	−0.02	–					
4. Number of children	1.30	1.31	0.12*	0.32**	−0.15**	–				
5. Preference to protect the home domain	4.27	0.73	0.04	−0.02	−0.10	−0.08	(0.91)			
6. Preference to protect the work domain	3.79	0.80	0.09	0.03	−0.04	0.10	0.38**	(0.86)		
7. Home permeability	2.98	0.87	−0.12*	0.01	0.36**	−0.07	−0.18**	0.02	(0.73)	
8. Work permeability	2.92	0.72	0.00	−0.05	0.12*	−0.11	−0.06	−0.18**	0.50**	(0.63)

$n = 313$

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$

[a] Dichotomous (0 = male, 1 = female)

[b] Dichotomous (0 = non-married, 1 = married)

Table 2 Study 1 results of hierarchical regression analyses on home and work boundary permeability

Variable	Home boundary permeability			Work boundary permeability		
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
Gender	−0.03	−0.04	−0.04	0.03	0.04	0.05
Marital status	0.01	0.01	0.02	−0.01	−0.01	−0.01
Hours worked per week	0.35**	0.36**	0.38**	0.11	0.10	0.10
Number of children	0.00	−0.01	−0.03	−0.08	−0.08	−0.06
Preference to protect the work domain		0.07	0.14*			−0.17**
Preference to protect the home domain			−0.18**		−0.06	0.01
R^2	0.13	0.13	0.16	0.02	0.02	0.05
F (df)	10.42** (4)	8.65** (5)	8.95** (6)	1.36 (4)	1.25 (5)	2.25* (6)
ΔR^2 (relative to model 1)		0.01	0.03**		0.00	0.03**

The path coefficients are standardized. R^2 = proportion of variance in dependent variable that is accounted for by the predictors (see Snijders and Bosker 1999)

$n = 313$

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$, one-tailed

are functionally distinct. Specifically, preference to protect the work domain is positively and significantly associated with home boundary permeability ($\beta = 0.14$, $p < 0.05$), suggesting that individuals who prefer to prevent non-work issues from intruding into their work domain are more likely to engage in work tasks while physically present in their non-work domain. The relationship between preference to protect the home domain and work boundary permeability is not statistically significant.

Consistent with boundary theories (Ashforth et al. 2000; Clark 2000) and our Study 1 results, individuals engage in "boundary work" (Nippert-Eng 1996), or activities that facilitate alignment between their segmentation preferences and their roles. Yet, this "enactive" view (Clark 2000) assumes that roles are already fixed, without considering that segmentation preferences may have contributed to individuals' decisions to select into these roles in the first place. We expect that individuals engage in efforts to achieve their segmentation preferences prior to role entrance, and that these efforts will result in the manifestation of preference into actual role segmentation. We address this issue of *proactive* boundary management in Study 2.

Study 2: Proactive Boundary Management

The possibility that people proactively make decisions regarding participation in work and personal domains is consistent with the idea that "people shape their worlds" (Clark 2000, p. 748; Snyder and Ickes 1985) by negotiating to create boundaries. Additionally, the person–environment fit view (Kristof-Brown et al. 2005) suggests that individuals assess which situations allow them to express their desired traits or constrain their behavior (Price 1974; Smith-Lovin 1979), and that they "gravitate toward those situations that foster and encourage the behavioral expression of their traits" (Snyder and Ickes 1985, p. 917). In the present research, we focus on "*proactive boundary management*," which refers to the decisions to enter into in a new work or non-work domain. The general proposition guiding this study is that, all else equal, individuals employ their preferred degree of role segmentation to make proactive choices regarding entrance into work and non-work role domains.

More specifically, we consider how the two dimensions of role segmentation preferences influence domain participation decisions when people are faced with the possibility of boundary permeability. For example, an individual may face a situation where she has the opportunity to accept a job at the same organization where her husband is employed, requiring her to enact roles of both employee and wife simultaneously. In this way, demands and characteristics of the work domain intrude into an existing home domain, creating interference between the two roles. While there is a tendency for individuals to engage in situations that facilitate strong, less penetrable boundaries (Ashforth et al. 2000), we expect that this tendency will be exacerbated for individuals with a high preference to protect either their work or their home domain. In other words, the negative relationship between boundary permeability and participation in another domain will be stronger for those with higher role segmentation preferences.

Job Acceptance with Significant Other

Individuals use numerous indicators to assess their degree of person–organization fit when making choices about their employment (Bretz and Judge 1994; Cable and Judge 1997), and we expect that the desirability of a job is, in part, dependent on preferences to protect the home domain. In this case, we consider accepting a job with one's significant other as the occurrence of non-work boundary permeability, since it requires an individual to allow intrusions from the work domain into an established personal domain and because it is typical for men and women to have to manage and integrate goals and demands associated with their families, careers, and their spouses' careers.

Indeed, more than one million couples are employed by the same organization (Hays 1995), 3.7 million American married couples co-own small businesses (Frayer and Noguchi 2014), and it is increasingly common for women who are majority owners of privately held firms to eventually employ their husbands (Fabrikant 2008). Although the prevalence of co-working spouses is evident, the desirability of integrating work and non-work domains by taking a job in an organization where a significant other already works may be difficult to predict in and of itself. On one hand, integrating non-work and work roles may create efficiencies and ease logistical burdens. For example, accepting a job where a significant other works might facilitate car-pooling and reduce complexities involved in navigating multiple health insurance plans. On the other hand, employees often view work as an escape from problems they experience in their domestic lives, and couples who work for the same company do not have the ability to leave family concerns behind (Hochshild 1997). Notably, though, there is preliminary evidence that job seekers consider organizations' leniency or restrictiveness with respect to romantic relationships in the workplace when evaluating their PO fit, and these assessments are associated with their intention to pursue employment in the organization (Pierce et al. 2012). Therefore, job candidates seek signals from hiring organizations regarding whether the degree to which they promote or inhibit boundary permeability matches their preferences for segmentation.

Researchers have suggested that mechanisms such as role identification (Tajfel and Turner 1986), salience (Powell and

Greenhaus 2010; Winkel and Clayton 2010), and centrality (Edwards and Rothbard 1999; Matthews and Barnes-Farrell 2010) underlie motivations for creating stronger or weaker boundaries around domains. For example, to the degree an individual identifies more with a work role than a non-work role, he or she will prefer to protect the work domain from non-work intrusions by focusing on work-related activities in order to place work as the primary recipient of attention and status preservation (e.g., Matthews et al. 2010; Powell and Greenhaus 2010; Winkel and Clayton 2010). Along these lines, identity salience theory (Stryker 1968) suggests decisions regarding potential participation in a new or less salient domain depend on the meaning of an established domain. Because an established personal domain is more salient than a new work domain in which individuals could potentially participate, the likelihood they will decide to participate in the less salient work domain depends on preferences to protect the established non-work domain. Individuals who prefer to protect their non-work domain will be less likely to accept a job in the same organization as their significant other, as this act constrains the extent to which the individual could maintain an impermeable non-work domain boundary.

Hypothesis 3 Preference to protect the non-work domain will moderate the relationship between non-work boundary permeability and job acceptance choices, such that the relationship will be more negative for individuals with a high preference to protect the non-work domain.

Relationship Formation with a Coworker

In addition to examining boundary management from the perspective of decisions to enter a work domain, we also examine decisions to enter a non-work domain. Consistent with seminal theory regarding boundary management, we consider initiating a romantic relationship with a coworker as the occurrence of work boundary permeability because it requires an intrusion from the non-work domain into the established work domain, and they reflect a common workplace experience (Nippert-Eng 1996). On one hand, estimates indicate that nearly 10 million workplace romances develop in the US annually (Spragins 2004), and 56 % of American business professionals report having had some kind of romantic relationship with a coworker (Vault Careers 2014). On the other hand, 39 % of employees report having avoided a potential romance that they would have otherwise pursued, specifically to avoid the pitfalls of dating a co-worker (Vault Careers 2014).

Although evidence suggests workplace romances are perceived more positively if they do not disrupt job productivity (Powell 1986), they are nevertheless associated with a negative stigma because they can result in conflict, tension, decreased productivity, perceptions of favoritism, and accusations of sexual harassment (Fisher and Welsh 1994; Pierce et al. 2000; Quinn 1977). Thus, when a single individual is employed, they likely consider how entering into a romantic relationship with a co-worker might complicate work experiences, reducing any proclivity to weaken the work boundary by initiating romantic relationships at work. But, pursuing a romantic relationship with a coworker has unique underlying motivations that are difficult to suppress, including emotions, interpersonal attraction, and mutual regard (Pierce et al. 1996). In light of evidence that individuals' attitude toward romance at work is an initiating factor with respect to workplace romances (Haavio-Mannila et al. 1988; Pierce et al. 1996), we argue that such choices are also somewhat dependent on individuals' preferences to protect their work domain.

Since an established work domain is more salient than a new personal domain in which individuals could participate, the likelihood that they will decide to participate in the less salient personal domain depends on their preferences to protect the established work domain. Thus, we hypothesize that individuals who have stronger preferences to protect the work domain will be less likely to initiate a dating relationship with an individual with whom they work because such choices would prevent them from maintaining an impermeable work domain boundary.

Hypothesis 4 Preference to protect the work domain will moderate the relationship between work boundary permeability and relationship initiation choices, such that the relationship will be more negative for individuals with a high preference to protect the work domain.

Method Overview

Respondents included 1253 undergraduate students from two sections of a management course at a university in the Southeastern United States. Our sample is well suited to assessing proactive boundary management because it consists of Millennials (individuals born between 1982 and 1999; Twenge 2010), a generation of individuals who prioritize work-life balance (Smola and Sutton 2002) and actively seek work environments that support their desired lifestyle (Myers and Sadaghiani 2010). Forty-nine percent of respondents are female and 45 % indicated they worked at least 20 hours per week. We conducted two independent sub-studies with distinct participants that paralleled each other with respect to structure and method but were designed to assess different hypotheses. Each sub-study was conducted in two parts, which were completed on-line. Participants accessed a link to an initial survey, in which they provided demographics and information about their personality and role segmentation preferences. While segmentation preferences vary between individuals, our theorizing suggests they influence relationships among factors that naturally vary within individuals; thus, we used a within-person experimental design.

One week after the initial survey, participants were randomly assigned to a manipulation check group or the experimental group, and were emailed a link to the survey. In both sub-studies, the participants read 8 vignettes in which manipulations were embedded, and responded to items that tap the variables in our study. Although vignettes have limitations (which we later discuss), they are conducive to testing causal hypotheses that involve choices that *could* result from being confronted with different situations (Jackson and LePine 2003). This approach also allowed us to employ a balanced repeated measures design, manipulation parallelism, and control of other powerful influences; thus, numerous threats to internal validity can be ruled out. To control for ordering effects, vignettes were presented in randomly determined sequences. The first sub-study ($n = 662$) addressed our third hypothesis regarding entrance into a work domain; participants were presented with vignettes whereby they rated the likelihood they would accept a hypothetical job. The second sub-study ($n = 452$) addressed our fourth hypothesis regarding entrance into a home domain; we presented participants with vignettes whereby they rated the likelihood that they would initiate a dating relationship with a hypothetical individual.

Analyses

We first conducted a CFA by specifying a two-factor segmentation preference model using Mplus 6.0 (Muthén and Muthén 1998–2010) and comparing it to a one-factor model, with all indicators loading onto a general segmentation preference factor. To test the third and fourth hypotheses, we employed multilevel modeling to simultaneously analyze both within- and between-person variance in individual outcomes. Because the within-units model (level-1) generates estimates of person-level slopes and intercepts that are used as dependent variables for the between-person model (level-2), we could test cross-level interactions while accounting for variables' differing sources of variance (Hoffman et al. 2000).

Sub-Study 1, Job Choice: Method

Within-Individual Manipulations

We assessed two levels of boundary permeability (*works in a different company* was assigned a zero and *works in the same company* was assigned a one). Further, although the main focus of our research is how role segmentation preferences impact role participation decisions, we also controlled for two important factors that play a role in job choice to identify the unique effect of segmentation preferences: job challenge (*low challenge* was assigned a zero and *high challenge* was assigned a one) and salary (*below average* was assigned a zero and *above average* was assigned a one)[1] (Chapman et al. 2005; Feldman and Arnold, 1978; Schwoerer and Rosen 1989). Thus, the study was a within-person $2 \times 2 \times 2$ design. The manipulations and checks are detailed in Appendix 1.

Between-Individual Level Measures

We used the same items and rating scales from Study 1 to assess *preferences to protect the home domain* and *preferences to protect the work domain* ($\alpha = 0.89$ and 0.83, respectively). We controlled for gender, employment status, motivation to learn, and achievement striving to rule out potential alternative explanations for our findings.[2]

Dependent Variable

Our dependent variable was *likelihood of job acceptance*. Participants were asked to rate, on a scale from 1 ("very likely") to 5 ("very unlikely"), the likelihood that they would accept a job at the organization described in each scenario. We opted for a single-item measure in order to minimize participant fatigue.

Results

Table 3 reports means, standard deviations, and correlations among the Study 2 variables relevant to job acceptance decisions. We note that the means of each manipulation are equal to 0.50, and the correlations between each of the manipulations and the other independent variables are equal to zero; this provides evidence of the randomness of assignment to conditions.

Providing additional support for Hypothesis 1, we conducted a CFA in which the Chi square and fit statistics

[1] Consistent with previous research (e.g., Honeycutt and Rosen 1997), *salary* levels were chosen so that an extremely significant effect of salary that was too high or too low would not bias the results.

[2] We controlled for *motivation to learn* using 3 items adapted from Noe and Schmitt (1986) ($\alpha = 0.90$), and include it along with the cross-level interaction with job challenge in our model because this trait reflects the desire to allocate effort to endeavors that involve growth, learning, and development. We controlled for *achievement striving* using Costa and McCrae's (1992) 10-item scale ($\alpha = 0.86$), and included it along with the cross-level interaction with salary in our model because this trait reflects characteristic differences in the degree to which money is perceived to be symbolic of desired competence, achievement, and success (Mitchell and Mickel 1999).

Table 3 Means, standard deviations, and intercorrelations between Study 2 variables

Variable	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1. Job acceptance	3.16	1.36									
Level 2											
2. Gender	0.50	0.50	0.02								
3. Employment	0.41	0.49	−0.01	0.09*							
4. Learning motivation	3.94	0.75	0.02	0.17**	−0.10**						
5. Need for achievement	3.98	0.54	−0.02	0.19**	0.01	0.52**					
6. Preference to protect home	3.74	0.79	0.03*	0.16**	−0.05**	0.10**	0.09**				
7. Preference to protect work	3.28	0.79	0.01	0.07**	0.02	0.21**	0.21**	0.36**			
Level 1											
8. Job challenges	0.50	0.50	0.37**	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00		
9. Salary	0.50	0.50	0.33**	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	
10. Boundary permeability	0.50	0.50	−0.06**	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00

Level 1 $n = 5296$; level 2 $n = 662$. Gender (0 = male, 1 = female), employment (0 = unemployed, 1 = employed) are dichotomous

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$

indicate that a two-factor model [χ^2 (19, $N = 662$) = 77.41; CFI = 0.99; SRMR = 0.04; RMSEA = 0.07] fits the data significantly better than does a one-factor model [χ^2 (20, $N = 662$) = 1028.72; CFI = 0.75; SRMR = 0.19; RMSEA = 0.31], and the change in Chi square is significant ($\Delta\chi^2 = 951.31$, $p < 0.01$). Factor loadings specified in the two-factor measurement model are all statistically significant (0.63–0.88; t values, 16.24–24.68), and preference to protect the home domain and preference to protect the work domain are only moderately correlated ($r = 0.42$), providing further support of two distinct dimensions. Determining that segmentation preferences can, in fact, be examined as two dimensions allowed us to test our third hypothesis. To do so, we sequentially estimated models in accordance with standard practices, whereby we first conducted a one-way analysis of variance (i.e., the null model) to examine the variance in likelihood of job acceptance. This preliminary model produces information about outcome variability at each of the two levels by partitioning dependent variable variance and calculating the amount of job acceptance variance that existed between individuals versus within (Hoffman et al. 2000), and provides evidence of significant between-individual variance to explain in ratings of job acceptance ($\tau_{00} = 0.06$, df = 655, $\chi^2 = 842.06$, $p < 0.001$). Further, the model allows estimation of the intraclass correlation coefficient (ICC), which indicates the proportion of between-individual variance to total variance in individual-level ratings of likelihood of job acceptance and represents the amount of variance potentially explainable by level-2 variables. The ICC showed that 16 % of the variance in ratings of likelihood of job acceptance exists between individuals. Both variance analyses justify progression to the next step of hypothesis testing.

We first estimated an intercepts and slopes as outcomes model to determine if including the interaction between boundary permeability and preferences to protect the home domain was warranted. We first entered level-1 controls (i.e., job challenges and salary) and level-2 controls (i.e., participant gender, employment, motivation to learn, and achievement striving), as well as the cross-level interactions between challenges and motivation to learn, and salary and achievement striving. Because a score of zero for each of the level-1 independent variables is meaningful, we did not center the level-1 variables. We did center the level-2 predictors on their corresponding grand means to facilitate interpretation of results (Bryk and Raudenbush 1992). The pseudo R^2 for this model shows that the controls account for 24 % of the variance in likelihood of job acceptance, and the Chi square ($\tau_{00} = 0.13$, df = 651, $\chi^2 = 1172.21$, $p < 0.001$) suggests there remained significant variance across individuals, justifying inclusion of boundary permeability and segmentation preferences as additional predictors.

To test Hypothesis 3, we estimated a model where the slope of boundary permeability varies non-randomly as a function of preferences to protect the home domain when predicting likelihood of job acceptance. Table 4 reports the model estimates. These results show that the preference to protect the home domain significantly moderates the permeability—likelihood of job acceptance relationship ($\gamma_{31} = -0.11$, $p < 0.05$), such that the relationship between permeability and likelihood of job acceptance is significantly more negative for individual with a high preference to protect their home domain. Also of note is that this effect is conservative in the sense that it is considered in the model along with the preference to protect the work domain and the interaction of boundary

Table 4 Study 2 results of hierarchical linear modeling analysis for job acceptance

Variable	Parameter estimates			
	Step 1		Step 2	
	Coefficient	SE	Coefficient	SE
Control				
Gender (γ_{01})	0.07	0.04	0.06	0.04
Employment (γ_{02})	−0.01	0.04	−0.01	0.04
Motivation to learn (γ_{03})	−0.05	0.04	−0.06	0.04
Achievement striving (γ_{04})	−0.12*	0.05	−0.12*	0.06
Job challenges (γ_{10})	0.99*	0.03	0.99*	0.03
Salary (γ_{20})	0.90*	0.03	0.90*	0.03
Motivation to learn × challenges (γ_{11})	0.24*	0.04	0.24*	0.04
Achievement striving × salary (γ_{21})	0.01	0.06	0.01	0.06
Variables of interest				
Home boundary permeability (γ_{30})			−0.18*	0.03
Preference to protect work domain (γ_{05})			0.01	0.04
Preference to protect home domain (γ_{06})			0.09*	0.04
Protect work × permeability (γ_{31})			0.00	0.04
Protect home × permeability (γ_{32})			−0.11*	0.04
Pseudo R^2	0.24*		0.26*	
ΔR^2			0.02*	

Level 1 $n = 5296$; level 2 $n = 662$. Gender, employment, motivation to learn, achievement striving, preference to protect work and home at level 2. Job challenges, salary, role overlap at level 1

* $p < 0.05$

permeability and preference to protect the work domain also in the model, neither of which were significant. These findings supports Hypothesis 3.

While our first sub-study provides insight into how segmentation preferences may influence decisions regarding participation in work domains, we also hypothesized that these preferences will influence participation in non-work domains. Thus, we proceeded to examine whether segmentation preferences influence decisions to initiate a workplace romance.

Sub-study 2, Dating Choice: Method

Within-Individual Manipulations

This sub-study largely paralleled the first in terms of structure. We assessed two levels of boundary permeability (*works in a different company* was assigned a zero and *works in the same company* was assigned a one). To identify the independent function of segmentation preferences in predicting domain participation, we also controlled for several factors that influence relationship initiation: physical attraction (*less attractive* was assigned a zero and *more attractive* was assigned a one)[3] (Walster et al. 1966) and personality (*introverted* was assigned a zero and *extraverted* was assigned a one)[4] (Shaw 1971). Thus, it was a within-person 2 × 2 × 2 design. The manipulations and checks are detailed in Appendix 2.

Between-Individual Level Measures

We assessed *preferences to protect the home domain* and *preferences to protect the work domain* using the same scales as in Study 1 (α = 0.88 and α = 0.82, respectively). We controlled for gender, employment status, openness to experience, and extraversion to rule out potential alternative explanations for our findings.[5]

[3] *Physical attractiveness* was manipulated by including a stock photograph of each hypothetical individual in each dating vignette. We asked four independent raters to rank the attractiveness of the individuals in a pre-selected set of stock photographs, and we selected the 16 photographs where there was unanimous agreement with

Footnote 3 continued
regard to relative attractiveness (8 females, 4 of which were consistently ranked as being more attractive than the other 4, and 8 males, 4 of which were consistently ranked as being more attractive than the other 4).

[4] *Personality* characteristics were identified on the basis of interviews with "singles" regarding personality preferences in dates.

[5] We expect that, while the importance of physical attractiveness of the target actor appears consistent across both men and women initiators (Eastwick and Finkel 2008), certain individual differences likely mitigate the effect of attractiveness. Thus, we controlled for personality traits *openness to experience* and *extraversion* using John and Srivastava's (1999) ten-item and eight-item scales, respectively, because individuals who are more curious and broad-minded (Barrick and Mount 1991) and whose personalities are congruent (Byrne 1971) may be more likely to initiate relationships with individuals at various levels of physical attractiveness. Reliabilities were α = 0.86 and α = 0.82, respectively.

Dependent Variable

The dependent variable in our study was *likelihood of relationship initiation*. To assess relationship initiation, participants were asked to rate, on a scale from 1 (very likely) to 5 (very unlikely), the likelihood that they would initiate a romantic relationship with the individual described in each scenario.

Results

Table 5 reports the means, standard deviations, and correlations among the variables. As in the job choice study, the pattern of correlations supports the random assignment to groups.

Providing additional support for Hypothesis 1, we conducted a CFA in which the Chi square and fit statistics indicate that a two-factor model [χ^2 (19, $N = 452$) = 96.08; CFI = 0.97; SRMR = 0.05; RMSEA = 0.10] fits the data significantly better than does a one-factor model [χ^2 (20, $N = 452$) = 601.63; CFI = 0.76; SRMR = 0.17; RMSEA = 0.28], and the change in Chi square is significant ($\Delta\chi^2 = 505.55$, $p < 0.01$). The factor loadings in the two factor model are statistically significant (0.61–0.85; *t* values, 12.19–19.77), and corresponded to the latent constructs. Finally, the two factors are moderately correlated ($r = 0.42$), demonstrating distinct dimensions.

We tested Hypothesis 4 by estimating a series of models that parallel those we tested with respect to job choice. We first conducted a one-way analysis of variance to examine the variance in relationship initiation and found that a significant amount of between-individual variance exists to be explained ($\tau_{00} = 0.13$, df = 450, $\chi^2 = 751.12$, $p < 0.001$). Further, 7 % of the variance in ratings of relationship initiation exists between individuals. These results provide justification in moving on to the next step of hypothesis testing. Thus, we specified an intercepts and slopes as outcomes model with level-1 controls (i.e., attractiveness and personality), level-2 controls (i.e., participant gender, employment, extraversion, and openness to experience), and cross-level interactions between attractiveness and openness, and personality and extraversion to determine if inclusion of the interaction between boundary permeability and preference to protect the work domain was warranted. The pseudo R^2 shows this model accounts for 26 % of the variance in likelihood of relationship initiation. The Chi square ($\tau_{00} = 0.17$, df = 446, $\chi^2 = 1008.70$, $p < 0.001$) suggests that significant variance exists across individuals, warranting inclusion of boundary permeability and role segmentation preferences as additional predictors. Thus, we tested Hypothesis 4, which states the slope of work boundary permeability varies as a function of preferences to protect the work domain when predicting likelihood of relationship initiation.

The results in Table 6 show that Hypothesis 4 is supported; preferences to protect the work domain moderated the relationship between work boundary permeability and likelihood of relationship initiation ($\gamma_{31} = -0.13$, $p < 0.05$), such that the relationship between boundary permeability and likelihood of relationship initiation is more negative for individuals with a high preference to protect their work domain. Notably, this effect is significant even with preference to protect the home domain and the interaction between boundary permeability and preference to protect the home domain in the model, underscoring the distinction between the two dimensions. Neither of these two terms is significant. Overall, our results indicate support for Hypothesis 4.

Table 5 Means, standard deviations, and intercorrelations between Study 2 variables

Variable	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1. Relationship Initiation	3.22	1.29									
Level 2											
2. Gender	0.47	0.50	−0.10*								
3. Employment	0.45	0.50	0.00	0.10*							
4. Openness to experience	3.62	0.54	0.06*	−0.11*	0.06*						
5. Extraversion	3.46	0.65	−0.06*	0.14*	0.01	0.23*					
6. Preference to protect home	3.73	0.72	−0.03*	0.10*	0.00	0.06*	−0.01				
7. Preference to protect work	3.29	0.70	−0.03	0.03	−0.08*	0.07*	0.05*	0.34**			
Level 1											
8. Attractiveness	0.50	0.50	0.42**	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00		
9. Personality	0.50	0.50	0.26**	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	
10. Boundary permeability	0.50	0.50	−0.10*	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00

$n = 3616$, level 1; $n = 452$, level 2. Gender (0 = male, 1 = female) and employment (0 = unemployed, 1 = employed) are dichotomous

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$

Table 6 Study 2 results of hierarchical linear modeling analysis for relationship initiation

Variable	Parameter estimates			
	Step 1		Step 2	
	Coefficient	SE	Coefficient	SE
Control				
Gender (γ_{01})	−0.22*	0.05	−0.21*	0.05
Employment (γ_{02})	0.02	0.05	0.01	0.05
Extraversion (γ_{03})	−0.35*	0.05	−0.35*	0.05
Openness to experience (γ_{04})	0.20*	0.06	0.21*	0.06
Attractiveness (γ_{10})	1.08*	0.03	1.08*	0.03
Personality (γ_{20})	0.67*	0.03	0.67*	0.03
Extraversion × personality (γ_{11})	0.44*	0.05	0.44*	0.05
Openness × attractiveness (γ_{21})	−0.11	0.06	−0.11	0.06
Variables of interest				
Work boundary permeability (γ_{30})			−0.26*	0.03
Preference to protect work domain (γ_{05})			0.04	0.04
Preference to protect home domain (γ_{06})			−0.05	0.04
Protect work × permeability (γ_{31})			−0.13*	0.05
Protect home × permeability (γ_{32})			0.01	0.05
Pseudo R^2	0.26*		0.28*	
ΔR^2			0.02*	

Level 1 $n = 3616$; level 2 $n = 452$. Gender, employment, openness, extraversion, and preference to protect work and home are at level-2. Attractiveness, personality, and role overlap are level-1

* $p < 0.05$

In contrast to a laboratory research setting, people have constraints in their lives that affect their decisions (e.g., having to accept a job without alternate options), and a broader array of instrumental and socio-emotional concerns are relevant. Thus, an examination of role segmentation preferences should consider relationships with a richer array of employee outcomes in settings where they are embedded in existing work and non-work domains.

Study 3: Predictive Validity of Segmentation Preferences

Accumulating research on outcomes associated with segmentation preferences has linked individuals' subjective perceptions of person–environment fit to attitudes such as job satisfaction and organizational commitment (Rothbard et al. 2005), general feelings of well-being and stress (Edwards and Rothbard 1999; Kreiner 2006), and perceptions of inter-domain transitions, psychological detachment from work, work-to-family and family-to-work conflict, and positive spillover (Chen et al. 2009; Kreiner 2006; Matthews and Barnes-Farrell 2010; Matthews et al. 2010; Rothbard et al. 2005; Winkel and Clayton 2010). However, most studies examining individuals' preferences for segmentation focus on protecting the home domain from work intrusions, and also disproportionately focus on emotions and attitudes. Thus, we have a relatively narrow understanding of how segmentation preferences are associated with work domain experiences, as well as whether effective boundary management facilitates role performance in work and non-work domains (Edwards and Rothbard 1999). To address these gaps, we explore the link between segmentation preferences and domain-specific job (non-work) satisfaction and job (non-work) performance through the combined lenses of social identity (Tajfel and Turner 1986) and organizational identification (Pratt 1998).

Consistent with prior research pinpointing individual differences as precursors to bases of identification (Kreiner and Ashforth 2004), we adopt the perspective that individuals' preferences to protect their work or non-work domain reflects the degree to which they identify with the preferred domain. Identifying with a work or non-work domain includes categorizing oneself as an active member of that domain, which can produce both a psychological and behavioral connection in the form of job satisfaction and in-role performance (e.g., Abrams et al. 1998; Riketta 2005; van Knippenberg and van Schie 2000). In turn, identification with one domain versus another positions the salient domain as the primary recipient of one's energy and attention (Kahn 1990). Thus, we expect that preferences to protect one's work or non-work domain are associated with feelings of domain-specific satisfaction—a pleasurable or positive emotional state resulting from the appraisal of one's work or non-work experiences (Locke 1976). Indeed, protecting their preferred domain allows them to feel a sense of belonging and reinforce their self-concept, and people respond positively to affiliations that amplify their immersion in the preferred domain and that affirm their salient identities (Riketta 2005).

Further, we expect that responses to domain identification will be reflected in individuals' work and non-work performance behaviors. Indeed, domain-based identification is proposed to motivate the direction, intensity, and persistence of individuals' behavior. Specifically, individuals will direct their efforts toward the preferred domain, exert greater effort toward their preferred domain, and persist in these efforts over time, all of which compel effective role performances (Pinder 1998; van Dick et al. 2008). This is aligned with research on self-consistency, whereby behavior that is consistent with highly valued goals is more intrinsically motivating (Sheldon and Elliot 1999; van Dick et al. 2008). Moreover, by attempting to prevent unwanted intrusions, individuals are striving to retain, protect, and build resources such as time and energy (Hobfoll 1989) that they can dedicate to the domain they wish to prioritize, enhancing in-role performance.

Hypothesis 5 Preference to protect the work domain is associated with (a) greater job satisfaction and (b) lower non-work satisfaction.

Hypothesis 6 Preference to protect the home domain is associated with (a) greater non-work satisfaction and (b) lower job satisfaction.

Hypothesis 7 Preference to protect one domain from the other is associated with higher evaluations of performance from stakeholders in the respective domain: (a) preference to protect the work domain is associated with higher evaluations of job performance and (b) preference to protect the home domain is associated with higher evaluations of non-work performance.

Method

Participants and Procedure

Participants in Study 3 were full-time employed Executive MBA students at a large Southeastern University in the U.S. Because employed MBA students may be particularly sensitive to work-life balance issues, we did not present the initial topic of interest to potential respondents when requesting participation in order to prevent self-selection bias (Olsen 2008). Rather, during their class meeting, we stated that they were being offered an opportunity to participate in a study designed to familiarize them with general Management concepts that would demonstrate potential linkages between individual-level phenomena and workplace outcomes of interest such as performance. They were asked to provide their name and email address on a sign-up sheet if they were interested in participating. Four days later, those who expressed interest received an email from the Principal Investigator with the consent form and survey link directing them to an electronic survey assessing demographics and items relevant to the study constructs. To minimize common method bias (Podsakoff et al. 2003), respondents were instructed to forward job performance and family performance survey links to their corresponding supervisor and/or significant other (including spouses and co-habitants) for completion. Of the 92 students, 65 completed the survey. The sample comprised 76.1 % Men, 71.6 % Caucasian, and 70.1 % of respondents were married. On average, respondents were 30.8 years old, had 8.9 years of work experience, and worked in a variety of fields including Engineering, Accounting, Military, IT, Architecture, Marketing, and Education. Overall, the sample provides a range of employees in different contexts providing variation in the constructs of interest, as well as in environmental constraints that did not exist in the vignette studies, such as Human Resource practices and communication technologies that may constrain role segmentation in a way that has greater ecological validity. A total of 37 supervisors completed the work performance survey, and 50 significant others completed the family performance survey. For their participation, focal participants received three points extra credit toward their course grade, supervisors received an embossed pen, and significant others received $5. At the end of the semester, the principal researcher provided feedback to the class about their aggregated responses with respect to stress levels, segmentation preferences, job satisfaction, etc. and correlations with supervisor-ratings of performance.

Measures

All measures were rated on a scale from 1 = strongly disagree to 5 = strongly agree, except segmentation preferences, which ranged from 1 = strongly disagree to 7 = strongly agree. We also included controls for gender, marital status, and number of children.

We used the same items from Study 1 to assess *preferences to protect the home domain* and *preferences to protect the work domain* ($\alpha = 0.90$ and 0.95, respectively). We measured *job satisfaction* with Cammann et al. (1983) 3-item scale, including "All in all, I am satisfied with my job" and *non-work satisfaction* with three parallel items adapted from Carver and Jones' (1992) scale, including "I find great comfort and satisfaction in my non-work life." Both measures are reliable ($\alpha = 0.96$ and 0.73, respectively). Supervisors rated participants' *job performance* with four items from Williams and Anderson's scale (1991), including "Adequately completes assigned duties." Significant others rated respondents' *non-work performance* using four items that parallel the job performance scale:

"Adequately completes household duties", "Fails to perform essential duties" (reverse-coded), "Fulfills family responsibilities", and "Neglects aspects of being a spouse/parent that he/she is obligated to perform" (reverse-coded). Both scales had sufficient reliability ($\alpha = 0.85$ and 0.72, respectively).

Analyses and Results

Table 7 reports means, standard deviations, and correlations. We conducted a series of hierarchical regressions to test Hypotheses 5–7, and the last step of each regression is reported in Table 8. Results offer partial support for Hypothesis 5. Preference to protect the work domain (a) is associated with higher reports of job satisfaction ($\beta = 0.34$, $p < 0.01$), but (b) our expected negative association with non-work satisfaction is non-significant. Hypothesis 6 received full support, such that preference to protect the home domain is (a) positively associated with non-work satisfaction ($\beta = 0.21$, $p < 0.05$) and (b) negatively associated with job satisfaction ($\beta = -0.29$, $p < 0.01$). These findings suggest that segmentation preferences are associated with individuals' satisfaction across domains such that individuals who prefer to protect a certain domain report being more satisfied with that preferred domain and less satisfied with the alternative domain.

The results provide partial support for Hypothesis 7. Contrary to Hypothesis 7a, preference to protect the work domain is not significantly associated with supervisor ratings of job performance. Conversely, Hypothesis 7b received support, such that preference to protect the home domain is positively associated with significant others' ratings of non-work performance ($\beta = 0.40$, $p < 0.01$). This suggests that individuals who prefer to protect their home domain from work intrusions invest their energy and attention toward this role, and are ultimately perceived by

Table 7 Means, standard deviations, and intercorrelations between Study 3 variables

	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1. Gender	0.23	0.42	–								
2. Marital status	0.75	0.44	0.06	–							
3. Number of children	0.46	0.83	−0.22**	0.20*	–						
4. Preference to protect the home domain	5.62	1.36	0.13	−0.20*	0.02	(0.90)					
5. Preference to protect the work domain	5.05	1.29	−0.12	−0.26**	−0.06	0.09	(0.95)				
6. Job satisfaction	3.27	1.06	−0.09	0.03	0.04	−0.18*	0.32**	(0.96)			
7. Non-work satisfaction	3.86	0.92	0.08	0.19*	0.07	0.17*	−0.04	0.11	(0.73)		
8. Work task performance	4.51	0.64	−0.16	−0.18	0.19	0.16	0.04	0.12	0.01	(0.85)	
9. Non-work performance	4.14	0.70	0.00	−0.02	−0.07	0.39**	−0.02	0.13	0.50**	0.35**	(0.72)

$n = 65$ (work task performance, $n = 37$; non-work task performance, $n = 50$). Gender (0 = male, 1 = female) and marital status (0 = non-married, 1 = married or living with significant other) are dichotomous

* $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$

Table 8 Study 3 results of hierarchical regression analyses

Variable	Job satisfaction	Non-work satisfaction	Task performance	Non-work performance
Gender	0.05	0.05	−0.12	0.02
Marital status	−0.32**	0.22*	−0.16	0.04
Number of children	0.14	0.04	0.24*	−0.08
Preference to protect the home domain	−0.29**	0.21*	0.22*	0.40**
Preference to protect the work domain	0.34**	−0.03	0.03	−0.07
R^2	0.25	0.08	0.13	0.17
F (df)	3.84** (5)	1.04 (5)	0.95 (5)	1.80 (5)
ΔR^2	2.15**	0.04*	0.00	0.16**

$n = 65$ for job and non-work satisfaction. $n = 37$ for task and non-work performance. The path coefficients are standardized. R^2 = proportion of variance in dependent variable that is accounted for by the predictors (see Snijders and Bosker 1999). ΔR^2 is relative to the respective model with only control variables (gender, marital status, number of children). Each model was estimated in a series of hierarchical regressions, but only the final model with all predictors is shown. In each case, the pattern of significant estimates remained the same across steps

* $p < 0.10$, one-tailed; ** $p < 0.05$, one-tailed

their significant other as effectively fulfilling their responsibilities in this role.

Discussion

Scholars have argued that role segmentation preferences need to be taken into account when determining the degree to which balancing multiple roles induces feelings of conflict (Kreiner 2006; Nippert-Eng 1996; Rothbard et al. 2005). However, our understanding of the dimensionality and functioning of segmentation preferences with regard to domain participation and other outcomes is imperfect in several ways (Greenhaus and Powell 2003; Kossek and Laustch 2012). To advance this work, we develop and test predictions that segmentation preferences are composed of two distinct dimensions, that individuals actively manage their domain boundaries to complement these two preferences, and that the two preferences differentially relate to various domain-specific outcomes. In support of our theorizing, we confirmed that there are two dimensions of role segmentation preferences: The preference to protect the home domain, and the preference to protect the work domain. First, CFAs from two independent samples provide evidence that the structure of the items constituted two distinct dimensions. Second, the CFAs from each sample indicated only a moderate correlation between preference to protect the home domain and preference to protect the work domain. Most importantly, perhaps, in all three studies these preferences are functionally distinct in ways that are consistent with our theorizing.

In Study 1 we found individuals who prefer to prevent work issues from intruding into their home lives report experiencing fewer work intrusions, whereas those who prefer to prevent non-work issues from intruding into their work domain report experiencing fewer non-work intrusions. This offers preliminary evidence that individuals actively manage their boundaries in a way that allows them to protect their preferred domain. In Study 2 we found that individuals not only actively organize their existing domains in a way that matches their preferences, but that they may also take proactive steps to anticipate and prevent misfit. In response to a series of vignettes, individuals who indicated a high preference to protect their home domain also reported being less likely to accept a job in a company where their significant other was already employed; likewise, while individuals in general were less likely to initiate a relationship if it involved a coworker, those who indicated a high preference to protect their work domain reported being even less likely to do so. Importantly, the results indicate that preferences to protect their work domain did not significantly influence whether accepting a job would create boundary permeability, and preference to protect the home domain did not significantly influence whether initiating a relationship would create permeability.

Finally, in Study 3, individuals who preferred to protect their work domain reported higher levels of job satisfaction, but there was no significant association with life satisfaction; further, individuals who preferred to protect their home domain reported higher levels of life satisfaction, as well as lower levels of job satisfaction. Therefore, segmentation preferences are associated with satisfaction across domains, such that individuals who prefer to protect a certain domain report being more satisfied with the preferred domain, and somewhat less satisfied with the alternative domain. Additionally, whereas preference to protect the work domain was not significantly associated with supervisor ratings of task performance, preference to protect the home domain was significantly and positively associated with significant other ratings of non-work performance. While we expected that individuals invest more energy and attention to their preferred roles, we found that these preferences primarily manifested in perceptions by family members that they were successfully fulfilling their responsibilities. This may be because there are many factors that contribute to effective job performance not captured by this characteristic, and that may be outside the individuals' control. Overall, these findings support our prediction that individuals do play an active part in managing their domain participation activities, and attempt to manage boundaries in a way that prevents interference with their more salient identity.

Practical Implications

Our results have important implications for organizations and employees alike. First, benefits may accrue to organizations and employees who are aware of the part that segmentation preferences play in employee reactions to organizational policies. Workplaces generally, and organizational policies more specifically, vary in the degree to which they create an environment that promotes segmentation or integration of work and non-work domains (Kreiner 2006; Rothbard et al. 2005). For instance, organizations that offer on-site childcare are promoting integration because this can increase the likelihood that parents' non-work thoughts and tasks will pervade the work domain (Ashforth et al. 2000). Similarly, work arrangements such as flextime are considered segmentation policies because they reinforce impermeable boundaries between work and home by restricting respective activities to defined times during the day (Rothbard et al. 2005). Given that not all employees seek the same policies, and they vary with respect to their appraisals of environments that permit segmentation or integration, organizations can move beyond attempts at blanket flexibility policies to consider that not all employees prefer attending to non-work tasks at work, and vice versa. For example, whereas human resource practices have traditionally downplayed customization in favor of standardization (Pearce 2001), companies are moving toward offering idiosyncratic deals (i-deals). This contemporary practice grants individuals special employment conditions that differ from their peers, and that satisfy their personal needs and preferences (Rousseau 2005). Thus, individuals can negotiate with their employer to adapt their work arrangements in way that benefits both the employee and the firm.

Yet, despite the potential to negotiate individual work arrangements, many characteristics of domains are difficult to alter, and research suggests that role demands are quite stable (Hecht and Allen 2009). Consistent with person–environment fit research, our results suggest individuals may anticipate this challenge, and proactively enter domains that fit their preferences before being in a position where they have to actively manage incongruence. Thus, they may select out of situations that could cause distress. In order for individuals to accurately assess the degree to which their segmentation preferences fit with an organization's culture and policies, companies can offer realistic job previews to present their expectations without distortion (Wanous 1992). Beyond providing accurate information about policies and underlying culture, hiring managers may also benefit from addressing expectations specific to the candidates' job, including the type of coworkers with whom they will interact and their potential supervisor's personality (Breaugh and Billings 1988), as this information will be most salient to their day-to-day segmentation experiences. If a job comprises elements an individual finds undesirable with respect to their preferred degree of segmentation, they will be able to make an informed employment decision.

Of course, many life events are driven by motivations and necessities beyond preferences for segmentation, so it is likely that individuals may accept a job where misalignment exists, or initiate a relationship with coworkers despite hesitations associated with potential complications. Therefore, if a situation ultimately results in misfit of segmentation preferences, organizations might need to consider practices that could help ameliorate associated dissatisfaction and discomfort. Of course, for this to happen, assessment of employee role segmentation preferences would be needed in order to identify and diagnose the source of experienced stress when misfit occurs. Thus, individuals may be able to mitigate feelings of stress by seeking consolation through various means, for example, stress relief techniques and the utilization of social support.

Another implication is that workplace romances, which necessarily involve boundary permeability, are quite common (Losee and Olen 2007; Peak 1995); however, the number of organizations implementing policies that deter dating among co-workers has doubled in the past 8 years (Wilke 2013). About one-third of companies prohibit romances between employees who report to the same supervisor, and 12 % ban romances between employees in different departments (Wilke 2013). In such contexts, our findings suggest a potential benefit in selecting individuals with high role segmentation preferences because they may be less inclined to violate anti-dating policies. Of course, research on role segmentation preferences is fairly new, and selecting on the basis of this characteristic should be considered only after additional research on the topic is conducted, and relevance to a job analysis and validity with respect to job outcomes, is established. Most critical, it is important to expand upon our analysis in Study 3 to consider how role segmentation preferences impact distal criteria related to employee effectiveness.

Limitations and Suggestions for Future Research

There were several limitations of our research we need to discuss. First, the field studies are cross-sectional and largely self-report—thus, it is difficult to make strong causal inferences. It is plausible, for instance, that people who are more satisfied with and perform better in a domain subsequently want to preserve and protect that domain. Such a possibility provides an alternative explanation for our findings in Study 3. However, there are three factors that should mitigate this concern. First, our hypotheses were guided by sound theory, and although there may be conceivable alternative causal explanations, they are less parsimonious. Second, we appropriately utilized self-reports when assessing private, personal events (Chan 2009), and used other-reports for assessments of an individual (Conway and Lance 2010). Finally, since we experimentally manipulated fit in Study 2, much stronger inferences regarding causality can be made. Although there were no such manipulations in Studies 1 or 3, the Study 2 findings indicate that preferences account for variability in phenomena in ways that are consistent with our theory.

Second, because participants in Study 2 responded to hypothetical vignettes, we cannot ensure our findings about proactive boundary management would generalize if these individuals encountered comparable choices in more realistic settings. For example, making job decisions is more complex than these scenarios account for. For instance, if an individual has a similar functional background as his or her significant other, or if two employees develop a close relationship over repeated interactions, they may be more likely to overlook their segmentation preferences and enact roles that allow for their domains to intermingle. Although this is not a trivial concern, the issue of generalizability must be weighed against practical challenges and the purpose of the research. For example, it would be very difficult to find a naturalistic research setting that would allow for the manipulation of job choice and dating opportunity situations such that strong causal inferences could be drawn about their influence on the effect of role preferences. However, future research could examine new workforce entrants in career services centers at universities, where investigators may be able to assess students' preferences for segmentation, interpretations of the degree to which interviewing organizations offer environments that fit their preferences, and whether they ultimately accept the job.

Although the effect sizes in Study 2 displayed significance according to our expectations, they were rather small in magnitude. This potential concern, however, should be considered in light of the fact that we are testing theoretically derived hypotheses to investigate what can happen rather than what does happen, and just as important, it is well known that small effects can be impactful (Abelson 1985; Cooper 1991; Mook 1983; Prentice and Miller 1992). Also, to the extent that our findings were not universally significant and were replicated across sub-studies, we are confident our results are not simply an artifact of sampling error or some other study artifact. Further, the results should be considered jointly with the findings of the two field studies we conducted. Although the same sets of variables were not considered in these studies, the findings are complementary, and together they paint a cohesive picture of role segmentation that can be developed in future research. Of course, though, we recognize the limitations in the study, and suggest research addresses these questions in a more realistic setting.

Next, the sample in Study 2 comprised undergraduate students. Given the nature of the study choices, some participants might have had difficulty drawing from realistic experiences to make their conclusions as, for example, many never had to make decisions regarding full-time professional employment. Similarly, participants were presented with target stimuli that likely oversimplified the choice and, thus, biased our results in unintended ways (Eastwick and Finkel 2008). However, the implications of these limitations may be ameliorated in that nearly half of the respondents were employed at least part-time, and the majority of the remaining participants will soon enter the workforce as college graduates. Thus, it stands to reason that participants understood the vignettes' implications with regard to choices that needed to be made. Also, research suggests that Millennials do not differ fundamentally from older generations in their work attitudes, orientations, or work ethic (Deal et al. 2010). What's more, popular media outlets highlight how organizational practices are adapting to the work values of Millennials (e.g., Aslop 2008) so their opinions and assessments are increasingly relevant.

Research should also examine the nature of segmentation preferences. Although we argue that these preferences are individual differences, it would be useful to explore what kind of difference they reflect and how they relate to other individual differences. Conceivably most applicable is the personality trait openness to experience, as it describes individuals' motivation to try new things and experience novel situations (Barrick and Mount 1991). From the results of Study 2, however, the correlations between openness and both preference to protect the home domain and preference to protect the work domain were weak ($r = 0.07$ and $r = 0.06$, respectively). Further, including openness as a control in our model did not significantly affect relationship initiation, nor did it mitigate the relationship between preference to protect the work domain and relationship initiation. Additionally, it would also be of interest to consider heritability factors and familial experiences of a child in predicting individuals' levels of segmentation preferences.

Last, it may be important to consider whether individuals are truly rational enough to first, identify their own role segmentation preferences and, second, act upon them. We believe even if individuals do not conscientiously place a label on these feelings, they can recognize which situations make them uncomfortable, and select out of these situations when possible. Research shows individuals choose to enter situations that provide opportunities to express their attitudes and dispositions (Snyder and Ickes 1985; Snyder and Gangestad 1982) and that boundaries "are partially a product of self-creation" Clark (2000, p. 759). Thus, it appears that individuals are rational enough to (at least attempt to, in lieu of situational constraints) enter into domains preserving their segmentation preferences.

Conclusion

In this set of studies, we sought to address some key lingering gaps in our theoretical understanding of role segmentation preferences. Specifically, we explored the degree to which individual preferences vary in direction and symmetry, and found that segmentation preferences display distinct dimensions of *preference to protect work from non-work intrusions* and *preference to protect non-work from work intrusions*. We also provided a more comprehensive explanation of *how* people manage their domain boundaries given their preferences, and found that, whereas people behave *enactively* by maintaining impermeable boundaries between existing domains, they also behave *proactively* by selecting into domains that are consistent with their preferred degree of segmentation. Finally, we extend the set of outcomes linked to segmentation preferences by investigating their differential effects on work and non-work satisfaction and performance. Though we acknowledge limitations in our research, our results from a diverse set of studies and analyses converge in a way that illuminates a clearer path forward for scholars, and paints a picture of segmentation preferences that is more elaborated. We do not view our research as the final word on these issues, but rather as a building block to follow up theory and research that could provide even greater insight into this important and interesting topic.

Appendix 1: Job Choice Scenarios

You graduated college a few years ago with a degree in accounting and you have just been offered a new position with an accounting firm. With this firm, you will be working in a [*fairly stable, predictable, and consistent* or *dynamic, challenging, and sometimes ambiguous*] environment that will require [*you to use the same basic skills for daily tasks that don't vary much from week to week* or *a number of different skills, creativity, and constant problem solving*]. In your job, you will have a [*low degree of responsibility, you will be given clear and specific directions for how to complete your work, and you will not need to be involved in much decision-making about how to schedule your time and work tasks* or *high degree of responsibility, significant control over work decisions, and even though you will not receive much guidance, you will have substantial freedom in how you schedule your time and work tasks*]. The average salary in the accounting industry for your position is approximately $60,000, and the firm is offering a salary that is [5 % below *or* 5 % above] the industry average. Your significant other, whom you have been dating for nearly 1 year, [works in a different company than the one *or* does work at the firm] that is offering you the job.

Manipulation Check

One hundred thirty-nine participants were randomly assigned to a manipulation check group. They read vignettes with manipulations of job challenge, salary, and permeability, and rated from 1 (not at all challenging) to 5 (very challenging), the degree to which they perceived the job context as challenging; on a scale from 1 (high) to 3 (low), the level of salary offered by the hypothetical organization; and by responding yes or no, whether they perceived their hypothetical significant other worked in the same organization. Ratings of job challenges, salary, and permeability were strongly correlated to our a priori categorization of these manipulations ($r = 0.69$, $r = 0.70$, and $r = 0.87$, $p < 0.01$, respectively).

Appendix 2: Dating Scenarios

You are currently single but you are interested in finding someone to spend more time with—thinking that perhaps this friendship could turn into a dating relationship. You have known [name] for a little while, and after a few times of talking with [him/her] you have thought about asking [him/her] out. [Name] has described [himself/herself] as [*quiet and introspective* or *outgoing and social*] and you have found [him/her] to be [*thoughtful and serious* or *energetic and light-hearted*]. One thing you often consider before initiating a dating relationship with someone is whether you work together. In this case, [*he/she does work in the same company as you do* or *you and he/she work in different companies*].

Manipulation Check

We conducted a manipulation check using the same subset of 139 participants from sub-study 1. For attractiveness ratings, participants indicated whether they wished to respond to questions regarding males or females, were directed to the respective photos, and rated from 1 (very unattractive) to 5 (very attractive) the individuals' attractiveness. Ratings were strongly correlated with the category of attractiveness we assigned to the manipulations ($r = 0.67$ female photos, and $r = 0.74$ male photos, both $p < 0.01$). Next, participants read vignettes with manipulations of personality and boundary permeability, and rated from 1 (very introverted) to 5 (very extraverted), the degree to which they perceived the individual to be extraverted, and whether (yes or no) they perceived that the hypothetical individual worked in the same organization. Participants' ratings of personality and boundary permeability were again strongly correlated to our a priori categorization of the vignettes ($r = 0.78$ and $r = 0.67$, $p < 0.01$, respectively).

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